

GOVERNANCE

Governance

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Governance

This document explains how decisions are made for **ARI** (the Agent Runtime Interface specification) and for **marrow** (its reference implementation). It is deliberately honest about the project's current stage and the path to neutral governance — because a standard that looks like one company's property does not get adopted.

Two things, governed differently

	ARI (the standard)	marrow (the implementation)
What it is	A language-neutral spec	An Apache-2.0 codebase
License	CC BY 4.0 (spec text)	Apache-2.0
Change process	<u>RFC process</u>	normal PRs + <u>STABILITY.md</u>
Goal	belong to the whole industry	be the canonical, conformant runtime

Keeping these distinct is a governance requirement, not a formality: anyone may implement ARI without touching marrow, and the spec must be able to outlive any single implementation.

Current stage (be honest)

ARI is at **v0.1 (Draft)** and marrow is **pre-1.0**. Today the project is **maintainer-led** (a small maintainer set, effectively a BDFL model). This is normal and appropriate for this stage — but it is explicitly a *stage*, not the end state. We do not pretend to be a foundation we are not.

Decision-making (now)

- **Routine changes** (bug fixes, docs, additive non-breaking features): a maintainer reviews and merges via PR.
- **Spec changes to ARI**: follow the RFC process. A Draft-stage spec can change with maintainer approval + a recorded rationale in the RFC; once a section reaches **Stable**, it follows the backward-compatibility rules in ARI-SPEC §11.
- **Breaking changes** require an RFC, a migration note, and a minor-version deprecation window.

Path to neutral governance (the commitment)

We will move ARI out of a single-vendor home as adoption justifies it. The triggers, in order:

1. **Second independent conformant implementation** exists and passes the conformance kit → publish a public RFC process and an open decision log.
2. **External contributors / adopters** beyond the originating maintainer → establish a working group with named stewards from more than one organization.
3. **Material industry adoption** → move the ARI spec to a neutral home (its own org/repo) under an open-governance body. MCP's donation to the Linux Foundation's Agentic AI Foundation (Dec 2025) is the model we intend to follow.

Until trigger 3, this repository is the spec's interim home, and marrow's maintainers are its interim stewards.

Conformance authority

"ARI-conformant" is not granted by us as a favor — it is **earned by passing the conformance kit** and claimed per ARI §10.4. We maintain the kit and the conformance registry; we do not gatekeep who may implement the spec.

Code of conduct

Participation is governed by CODE_OF_CONDUCT.md.

Amending this document

Changes to governance follow the same RFC process as spec changes, so the rules for changing the rules are themselves on the record.